

“So, Like, It’s All a Mix of One”: Intersecting Contexts of Adolescents’ Ethnic-Racial Socialization

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Abstract

Cultural-ecological theories posit that ethnic-racial identity development is shaped by transactions between contexts of ethnic-racial socialization, yet research considering intersections among multiple contexts is limited. In this study, Black, Latino, White, and Asian American adolescents ($N = 98$; $M_{\text{age}} = 16.26$, $SD = 1.09$; 55.1% female-identifying) participated in surveys and focus group discussions (2013-2014) to share insights into ethnic-racial identity development in context. Using consensual qualitative research, results indicated: (a) family ethnic-racial socialization intersects with community-based, peer, media, and school socialization; (b) ethnic-racial socialization occurs outside family through intersections between peer, school, community-based, and media settings; and (c) ethnic-racial socialization is embedded within systems of racial oppression across contexts. Discussion includes implications for future research and interventions supporting youth ethnic-racial identity.

Keywords: adolescents, ethnic-racial identity, ethnic-racial socialization, family, peers, school

“So, Like, It’s All a Mix of One”: Intersecting Contexts of Adolescents’ Ethnic-Racial Socialization

The proportion of U.S. public school students from ethnic-racial minoritized backgrounds increased from 39% in 2000 to 52% in 2017 (Hussar et al., 2020). By 2029, projections indicate that youth of color will comprise approximately 56% of U.S. public school enrollment, and by 2044, White Americans will no longer make up the majority of the U.S. population (Colby & Ortman, 2015; Hussar et al., 2020). Coupled with mounting evidence for the negative developmental consequences of ethnic-racial-based discrimination and racism (Benner et al.,

2018), these continuing increases in ethnic-racial diversity have made clear the imperative to study and support ethnic-racial identity (ERI) development. ERI is a multidimensional construct that includes the normative developmental processes of learning and gaining a sense of understanding about one's ethnic-racial group membership (Umaña-Taylor et al., 2014). Both theory and empirical evidence suggest that the ERI processes of exploration and resolution are developmental competencies that are universal (i.e., relevant for all youth), showing links with positive psychosocial and academic adjustment and serving as protective factors that buffer youth of color from adverse consequences of ethnic-racial-related stress (Rivas-Drake et al., 2014; Umaña-Taylor, 2016). ERI development gains prominence during adolescence as youth grow in cognitive maturity to reason about abstract concepts and navigate more complex and diverse social settings (Williams et al., 2020).

To support avenues for positive ERI development, critical questions become: How do adolescents learn about their ERI? Who is doing the teaching? Where does this learning take place? Ethnic-Racial socialization encompasses the messages that are conveyed to youth across all of their social environments about the role of ethnicity and race in their lives and society, which shape the meaning that adolescents ascribe to their ethnic-racial group membership, knowledge of the history and values of their group, and beliefs about how others view and treat members of their group and other groups (Hughes et al., 2016). In line with this transactional conceptualization of ethnic-racial socialization and identity, efforts to study adolescent ERI development in context have advanced considerably (Rogers et al., 2020; Umaña-Taylor, 2016), including a special issue dedicated to the topic in *Child Development* (Seaton et al., 2017). Most of this research has focused on family ethnic-racial socialization, with the results of hundreds of studies collectively showing robust links between youth ERI development and the degree to which parents transmit implicit and explicit messages about cultural heritage, traditions, and pride to their children (i.e., cultural socialization; Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020). Research on other social contexts of adolescents' ERI development has started to expand through interdisciplinary collaboration and methodological innovation. For example, a growing number of studies have examined peer group diversity influences on adolescents' ERI using social network analysis (Santos et al., 2017), and studies bridging developmental and education frameworks have examined teacher and school-level influences on adolescents' ERI (Byrd, 2016).

As this research advances, multiple levels of analysis are required to capture the many social actors and settings involved in ethnic-racial socialization, posing challenges for researchers to examine transactions across social contexts in any single study. To complement the contributions of quantitative survey studies, qualitative research offers key strengths to developmental science in this regard. In the current study, we sought the perspectives of ethnographically diverse adolescents to gain insights into how they have learned about their ERI, specifically focusing on who is engaged in the socialization process and where this developmental process unfolds across multiple social contexts of their lives. In open-ended focus group discussions, we adopted an exploratory approach to ask adolescents to describe activities they have participated in that have taught them about their ethnic-racial background, including where and with whom they engaged in this exploration process, and to ask adolescents how they have come to understand their ERI over time as they have grown older. Using a semi-structured protocol, facilitators referenced statements from a survey measure of ERI development that adolescents had completed and asked them to think about examples from their personal experiences. The resulting conversations that adolescents had about their own ERI development included rich discussion of ethnic-racial socialization processes – the ways in which adolescents learn about their ERI in the social contexts and from the social actors of their everyday lives, including family, community-based settings, peers, school, the media, and the broader macro-level sociohistorical context. In analyzing these qualitative data, our aim was to contextualize existing evidence and identify gaps in our understanding of ethnic-racial socialization and identity that have been rendered difficult to examine with prevailing quantitative methods.

Advancing Cultural-Ecological Models of Ethnic-Racial Identity Development

According to the bioecological model (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2006), transactions between various proximal microsystems of development (e.g., family, peers, schoolteachers) form the mesosystem – relationships that exist between two or more settings (e.g., interactions between families and peers). Extensions of the bioecological model further advanced this notion, emphasizing that transactions between youth's daily social communities, including interconnections between their families, schools, and neighborhood settings, serve as distinct cultural pathways that shape development in context (Vélez-Agosto et al., 2017). Consistent with ecological theories accounting for systems of social stratification and marginalization in development, including the integrative model of minority youth development (García Coll et al.,

1996) and the phenomenological variant of ecological systems (PVEST) theory (Spencer et al., 1997), the processes of ethnic-racial identity, socialization, and discrimination have been conceptualized as interdependent, inseparable, and mutually defining, thus requiring their examination together in studies of ethnic-racial-related developmental processes (Hughes et al., 2016). As more empirical studies begin to test this conceptual model for understanding adolescents' ERI in context, important questions remain about the interface of multiple social contexts in shaping ERI (Rogers et al., 2020; Seaton et al., 2017).

Researchers drawing from cultural-ecological models are often met with a common critique: that these theories are not falsifiable, and thus, not testable in a single hypothesis or study. Research at the frontier of testing transactional assumptions of cultural-ecological models has started to make key advances in examining ethnic-racial socialization in multiple contexts. In quantitative approaches that test additive contributions, for example, studies of ethnic-racial minoritized young adults have demonstrated that parents and peers jointly contribute to cultural socialization practices (Wang et al., 2015), and both parent and peer socialization are positively associated with ERI commitment (Nelson et al., 2018). Considering interactions between family and school variables, results from an experimental study of a school-based ERI-focused intervention with ethno-racially diverse adolescents have shown that positive effects on ERI exploration were stronger for those with higher initial levels of family ethnic-racial socialization (Sladek et al., 2021). Longitudinal research examining the interaction of family and neighborhood socialization among U.S. Mexican-origin families found that the positive effects of mothers' ethnic-racial socialization on adolescents' ERI exploration was more pronounced for those living in neighborhoods with a relatively lower concentration of Latino families (White et al., 2018). Research utilizing a person-centered approach revealed four profiles of adolescents' ethnic-racial socialization when simultaneously considering the multiple contexts of family, school, neighborhood, and the Internet, with results showing that levels of critical consciousness (i.e., awareness of societal inequities, engagement in activism) were highest for adolescents with a profile characterized by higher family ethnic-racial socialization and higher discrimination in both neighborhood and online settings (Byrd & Ahn, 2020).

In addition to this quantitative evidence for statistical interactions and profiles indicated by multiple variables, qualitative inquiry is uniquely positioned to explore the ways in which adolescents learn about their ERI through a constellation of social context influences. For

example, in a qualitative interview study, Mexican American adolescents identified ethnic-racial socialization messages across a wide range of contexts, including family, peers, and the broader social systems of race and racism (Quintana et al., 2010). In another study, interviews with U.S. East Asian adolescents from immigrant families revealed promotive ethnic-racial socialization messages that youth received from family and their broader ethnic community, as well as the stereotypes and discrimination these youth faced from peers and U.S. mainstream society (Yoon et al., 2017). In a study of African American, Chinese American, Dominican American, and European American middle school students, interviews showed ways in which societal ethnic-racial stereotypes inform ERI development, including how adolescents contrast stereotypes about other ethnic-racial groups to understand their own ERI and actively resist confirming stereotypes about their own group (Way et al., 2013). Despite identifying multiple contexts of ethnic-racial socialization that adolescents talk about as factors that inform their ERI development, none of these prior qualitative studies examined ways in which the interface between more than one context may offer added insights into how adolescents learn about their ERI. For example, adolescents are socialized by their family and by their peers but less is known about the meaning that adolescents find in experiences when family and peers are involved together in socialization processes, such as participating in cultural activities with family and with peers in the same setting.

Current Study

Following transactional cultural-ecological theories of development (Vélez-Agosto et al., 2017), transactional perspectives on ethnic-racial socialization and identity development (Hughes et al., 2016), and recent calls in the literature to further enrich the science of adolescent ERI development with critical attention to social context influences (Rogers et al., 2020; Seaton et al., 2017; Umaña-Taylor, 2016), we adopted a qualitative research approach to explore the ways in which adolescents learn about their ERI through multiple social contexts of development, including family, peers, school, community-based settings, the media, and the broader macro-level sociohistorical context. We conducted focus group interviews with ethno-racially diverse adolescents to gather in-depth insights into how they have learned about their ethnic-racial background and explored this aspect of their identity in context. Our analytic approach drew on the strengths of consensual qualitative research (CQR; Hill et al., 2005) to encourage multiple perspectives and balance researcher biases in the analysis process, including a research team that

mirrored the ethnic-racial composition of the Black, Latino, White, and Asian American adolescents in our study. Consistent with the evolving, iterative nature of qualitative research questions (Agee, 2009), and the systematic steps of the CQR method (Hill et al., 2005), our analytic focus in the current study was informed by a priori theoretical conceptualization and refined through multiple rounds of coding the data as a collective team of researchers. Using a qualitative approach afforded key opportunities to explore the role of sociocultural context in adolescents' ethnic-racial socialization experiences and the implications of these experiences for promoting ERI development. We invited adolescents to share their own reflections and experiences regarding how they have learned about their ERI to gather data on social context influences that reflects their unique voices, opinions, and perspectives – helping developmental science move closer to understanding this key developmental competency in context. In addition, our exploratory analysis allowed us to consider ways in which adolescents describe their own socialization experiences and identities without being bound by assumptions of confirmatory quantitative analysis (e.g., statistical interactions) that, by design, cannot offer insights into the depth and breadth of how adolescents reflect on, explain, and experience these dynamic processes.

Method

Participants and Data Collection Procedures

Focus group participants were selected from a sample of 1,553 students recruited from an ethno-racially diverse high school in a major metropolitan area in the southwestern U.S., during the 2013-2014 school year, and as part of an initiative to develop an intervention program to support adolescents' ERI development (Umaña-Taylor & Douglass, 2017). The school context was selected due to the high degree of ethnic-racial diversity among students (Simpson's Index of Diversity score of 0.66; Juvonen et al., 2006), in which no single ethnic-racial group comprised a majority of the student population. The school was located in a relatively affluent neighborhood; however, the district followed an open-enrollment process whereby any student who lived in the state could apply to attend any public school in the state, regardless of residential zoning. Thus, although located in an affluent community, it was a Title I school with a high degree of socioeconomic diversity. Finally, the school was situated within a metropolitan area and state characterized by close proximity to the U.S.-México border, and where the ethnic-racial groups with the largest representation were White and Latino. All students completed a

self-administered survey distributed by teachers during class time, which gathered demographic data (44.0% White, 23.8% Latino/Hispanic, 20.9% Black/African American, 3.7% Asian/Asian American, 3.2% American Indian/Native American, 2.8% Other, 1.5% did not provide ethnic-racial identification; $M_{age} = 16.18$, $SD = 1.12$; 45.9% male identifying, 54.1% female identifying) and assessed ERI exploration (7 items; $\alpha = .85$) and resolution (4 items; $\alpha = .86$) using the Ethnic Identity Scale (EIS; Umaña-Taylor et al., 2004). We selected focus group methodology to gather in-depth information regarding adolescents' ERI-related experiences through personal reflection and group discussion (Morgan, 1997). To facilitate participants' comfort discussing ethnicity and race in a group of similar peers, and consistent with best practices (Morgan, 1997), we formed focus groups using a stratified sampling approach to maximize group homogeneity on the following three characteristics: ethnic-racial group (i.e., Black, Latino, White, or Asian American), grade level (i.e., 9th/10th grade or 11th/12th grade), and ERI developmental status (i.e., Achieved or Diffused; Umaña-Taylor et al., 2004). Exploratory two-step and confirmatory k-means cluster analyses of EIS scores were used to classify participants as more ERI Achieved (i.e., have explored more, have a greater sense of clarity) or more ERI Diffused (i.e., have explored less, have less clarity), relative to peers of the same ethnic-racial and grade-level group (see Umaña-Taylor & Douglass, 2017, for further details). A total of 98 participants ($M_{age} = 16.26$, $SD = 1.09$; 44.9% male identifying, 55.1% female identifying) participated in one of 14 focus groups (see Table 1).

A Latina professor and a White female postdoctoral researcher facilitated focus group interviews, which took place during the school day. Facilitators followed a semi-structured open-ended interview protocol designed to be flexible and sensitive to variability in participants' ERI developmental status. Facilitators set conversation ground rules (e.g., respect, confidentiality) and validated the diversity of adolescents' ERI-related views and experiences by noting that for some teenagers, their ethnicity or their ethnic heritage was something that was very relevant or important to them, and for others it was not. Next, facilitators referenced the survey:

When you took the survey a few weeks ago, there were questions asking you about whether or not you had done things to figure out what your ethnicity or ethnic heritage was and what it meant to you. For example, you were asked how much you agreed or disagreed with the statement, "I have participated in activities that have taught me about my ethnicity."

In groups of participants who scored higher on ERI exploration and resolution (i.e., Achieved), facilitators asked participants to think about examples from their personal experiences:

For the next few minutes, think about three different activities that you've done that you think have taught you about your ethnicity. It doesn't have to be something you've done recently. It can be something you did a few years ago. Or it can be something that you just recently did. I'm especially curious about what the activity is, but then also, how you felt that the activity taught you about your ethnicity or your ethnic heritage. What was it about the activity that was meaningful to you?

In groups of participants who scored lower on ERI exploration and resolution (i.e., Diffused), facilitators asked participants to think about reasons for why other adolescents might not engage in these activities to open up the conversation in a way that validated these participants' experiences and also led to reflection on their personal experiences:

For the next few minutes, think about why you think some teenagers don't participate in activities that might teach them about their ethnicity. Basically I'm wondering why teenagers wouldn't participate in these kinds of activities. I'm curious if you think this is done on purpose? Do you think some teens specifically avoid activities related to their ethnicity, and why do you think this is? Why do you think some teens might not have opportunities to learn about their ethnicity?

To facilitate participants' engagement and comfort in the group setting, participants were first asked to answer questions independently by writing their ideas on a notepad and then to share their ideas with the group; these hand-written notes were for students' personal use and not collected by the research team. Facilitators used follow-up prompts to elicit conversation about how adolescents had learned about their ERI in various social contexts (e.g., family, peers, school, the Internet). For example, after listening to what students generated on their own, facilitators asked follow-up questions before moving on, such as: Did anyone write down any activities they did with their friends? Can you explain what this activity was like? Each focus group lasted 60-90 minutes and was audio-recorded. One trained research assistant was present in each group as a notetaker to record the order in which participants spoke; these notes were later used to match comments with individual participants in the transcripts. Audio recordings were transcribed verbatim by trained research assistants using the notetaker log as a guide. The Arizona State University Institutional Review Board approved all procedures.

Coding Procedures and Analytic Strategy

A White male postdoctoral researcher with emerging expertise in ERI theory and research (i.e., the first author), in close collaboration with a Latina professor with considerable expertise in ERI theory and research who collected the data (i.e., the second author), led a diverse coding team in analyzing the focus group data to answer the originally envisioned research question: How do family, peers, and schools shape ethnic-racial identity development? The analytic strategy was informed by a consensual qualitative research (CQR) approach, which includes elements of postpositivist and constructivist research paradigms (Hill et al., 2005). Key components of CQR include: (a) multiple coders throughout the analysis process to encourage multiple perspectives and examination of researcher bias; (b) consensus coding through discussion to arrive at shared meaning, relying on mutual respect and co-involvement among researchers; and (c) use of auditors outside the primary coding team to independently assess coding and analysis procedures (Hill et al., 2005; Ponterotto, 2010). Consistent with CQR, data coding and analysis involved a systematic, iterative, and collaborative process that evolved through ongoing discussions as members of the team independently coded the data, learned from discussing codes and interpretations with one another, revisited the data to apply new and revised codes, and summarized findings.

Coding Team

The coding team comprised 13 researchers who self-identified as Black ($n = 4$), Latino ($n = 3$), Asian/Asian American ($n = 2$), and White ($n = 4$). The coding team was also diverse with respect to gender (9 female-identifying members; 4 male-identifying members), age (range: 20–54 years), and prior research experience (e.g., master's and doctoral students, postdoctoral researcher; $M = 4.22$ years of experience; range: 0–9 years). We read and discussed theoretical perspectives relevant to the study objectives to establish operationalizations for key concepts (e.g., ERI exploration) prior to analysis. For the purposes of reflexivity, and following CQR recommendations (Hill et al., 2005), we also engaged in regular self-reflection and discussion of researcher positionality, biases, and expectations to examine the effects of our respective social positions on the research process (Berger, 2015).

Data Coding and Analysis

Informed by a CQR approach, three primary steps to data coding and analysis included (a) identifying domains, (b) coding core ideas within these domains, and (c) engaging in cross-

analysis to construct themes that emerged across the data. To begin, we established a start list of social context domains in which adolescents learn about their ERI, which was informed by reviewing the literature (Hughes et al., 2016; Umaña-Taylor, 2016) and the focus group interview data. This start list initially included family, peers, and school. Based on a preliminary review of the data, we expanded the list of domains to include community-based contexts (e.g., places of worship, community-based organizations), media (e.g., the Internet, music), and the broader macro-level sociohistorical context in which all social settings of adolescents' daily lives are embedded (e.g., systems of racial oppression, current events).

Next, all members of the coding team independently read each transcript, coded the data, and participated in weekly group discussions to collectively develop and define codes. All codes for this project answered the question of how adolescents have explored and learned about their ERI via social context influences (see Table 2). For example, we coded "hearing stories from family" as one way adolescents reported learning about their ERI from parents, grandparents, and other elders, which included accounts of family members' lived experiences, oral histories, and folktales. As another example, we coded "discussions with peers" as one way adolescents learned about their ERI from talking with friends, classmates, and other peers about issues related to ethnicity and race. Team members took turns presenting their independent coding in weekly meetings, and codes were developed, defined, and applied to the data according to group consensus discussions (Hill et al., 2005). During this step, the first author developed memos for points of convergence and disagreement and maintained regular contact with the second author and additional team members regarding the consensus process. Following CQR recommendations, the second author reviewed drafts of the codebook as an auditor, bringing an additional expert perspective to the coding process as an insider to the study but an outsider to the coding team to further check biases and provide recommendations for revisions. See Table 2 for codes within each of the six social context domains. Once the codebook was finalized through coding all 14 transcripts, each coded transcript was reviewed again independently by two team members to check that the codes were applied consistently across the data in accordance with shared meaning reached through the consensus process. This pair of researchers always included an ethnic-racial ingroup and outgroup member to ensure that cultural insider and outsider perspectives were built into data checking procedures. For example, coded data from Black adolescents were checked by a Black researcher and a Latina researcher. Any

discrepancies within pairs were resolved via group consensus discussions with a team of six researchers, including the first and second authors.

From this process of working together as a team, adolescents' accounts of how they have learned about their ERI at complex intersections of multiple contexts came into sharper focus. We became aware that the initial domains (e.g., family, peers) overlapped visually in the data. For example, excerpts were coded for ways in which family and peers influenced adolescents' ERI development, rather than distinctly separate influences. As another example, multiple codes crossed domains, such as "cultural media with family," and thus their location in one social context domain (and not the other) was arbitrary. Unlike the initial format of our codebook, many participants did not compartmentalize social contexts when discussing how they have explored and learned about their ERI. As such, our coding revealed the more interwoven, interconnected nature of social interactions and settings in adolescents' lives that form the ethnic-racial socialization landscape. For example, when describing activities he participated in to learn about his ERI, specifically attending quinceañeras, a Latino 16-year-old male student explained, "Some people will go to church first and then they'll go to the party later. Then there's also family and friends there and then there's also music . . . So, like, it's all a mix of one." As another example, when asked about what researchers should keep in mind when developing ERI-focused programs to support exploration, a Black 17-year-old male student explained, "It doesn't just start at school though . . . It starts at your house, it starts when you first wake up." "And your friends," added a Black 16-year-old female student. "It starts when you first wake up and you go to sleep, it's an everyday thing," the male student finished.

The nuance with which adolescents discussed learning about their ERI from a variety of sources across social settings signaled the importance of considering intersecting contexts of ethnic-racial socialization as a novel contribution to extant literature (Hughes et al., 2016; Umaña-Taylor, 2016). At this stage, a White female professor with substantial expertise in qualitative research methods (i.e., the third author) reviewed codes and evidence from the data as an external auditor. Feedback from this audit was incorporated through continued discussions among the first, second, and third authors. Given the consistency with which intersections between more than one social context occurred across the data (i.e., all 14 focus groups,) as well as the evolving, iterative nature of qualitative research questions (Agee, 2009), we refined the focal research question for the current analysis: In what ways do social contexts intersect to

inform *adolescents' ERI development*? Informed by the data and our analysis, we define intersecting contexts as the interface of overlapping and interwoven social influences that synergistically shape how adolescents learn about their ERI in a manner that reflects the fluidity with which youth experience and make sense of navigating the myriad settings of their everyday lives. Based on the ways adolescents talked about these influences in discussions about their ERI development, intersecting contexts of ethnic-racial socialization cannot be teased apart from one another or fully understood without considering the simultaneous influences of more than one social context. This definition is consistent with and further supported by notions from the bioecological model regarding microsystem relationships that form the mesosystem as a unique layer of developmental influence (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2006) and with transactional/ecological frameworks calling for attention to interconnections between ethnic-racial socialization, identity, and discrimination across multiple social contexts during adolescence (Hughes et al., 2016).

Following CQR, we then conducted cross-analysis to systematically extract all coded excerpts across all focus groups in which participants mentioned learning about their ERI at the intersection of more than one social context (e.g., family and peers, school and peers), resulting in 15 possible combinations. We used Dedoose software to facilitate this process of extracting co-occurrence across domains. Team members independently re-coded all data that included social context intersections and then met to develop new codes through consensus discussions. These new codes (see Table 3) answered the new iteration of the research question. For example, analyzing the overlap between family and peer codes resulted in the code, “engaging in cultural activities with family and peers,” as one of the ways in which participants learned about their ERI through a social context intersection. These codes were then used to construct the final themes that resulted from these multiple phases of analysis. Finally, all authors reviewed final summaries and example quotes, providing further feedback integrated into the presentation of results.

Results and Discussion

Our analysis of the ways in which adolescents discussed learning about their ERI from the confluence of more than one social context coalesced around three primary themes: (a) family ethnic-racial socialization occurs at the intersections of multiple social contexts, including in community-based settings, with peers, through media, and in school; (b) ethnic-racial

socialization occurs outside the family setting through intersecting influences of peers, school, community-based contexts, and media influences; (c) the everyday settings in which adolescents learn about their ERI are embedded within systems of racial oppression (i.e., racism, prejudice, stereotypes). In this section, we present evidence from the data for these themes alongside a discussion of these results to situate our findings with regard to extant theory and empirical research. The goal of this study was to explore the ways in which ethnic-racial socialization processes emerge for youth from diverse ethnic-racial backgrounds and to solicit the perspectives of youth across a continuum of ERI development (i.e., Achieved and Diffused ERI status). In Table 3, we present a summary of the occurrence of codes across groups of adolescents in our study to represent the breadth of examples across our data and highlight the potential for future research to further consider similarities and differences, though our goal was not to compare these contexts of ethnic-racial socialization across groups.

Intersecting Social Contexts of Family Ethnic-Racial Socialization

In discussing how they have learned about their ERI from family, participants described multiple ways in which family ethnic-racial socialization (i.e., participating in cultural activities/traditions and learning about cultural heritage) also includes and occurs in combination with other social actors and settings, including community-based contexts, peers, media, and school. For instance, participants explained that they attended community events with their families, which provided opportunities to engage in cultural participation and facilitated a process of passing down historical knowledge regarding their cultural heritage, thereby supporting ERI exploration. One participant explained how she learned about her ERI by attending community events with family:

Um, I don't know if anyone's been to the Japanese festival? But they like have one for like, African Americans, so we went there, and they have, like, different dances and foods and stuff, so, yeah . . . [I went with] my mom . . . my aunts. (Black Achieved ERI 15-year-old female student)

Similarly, when asked about attending events that have helped them learn about their ERI, another participant shared:

Well sometimes me and my family go to mariachi festivals to listen to all the music because we like that music. And it, like . . . reminds us of, like, when we go to México

and all the music they have, so I enjoy going there [to local festivals]. (Latina Achieved ERI 16-year-old female student)

Thus, families attending cultural events and activities in the local community facilitates adolescents' ethnic-racial socialization. Participants also described learning about their ERI through family connections with community-based organizations that promote observance and maintenance of traditions from their cultural heritage, both locally and through traveling:

Like, it was recently a Lunar New Year, and . . . so they had, like, a festival at, like, um . . . that whole area [local ethnic enclave], yeah, that's like a lot of Vietnamese stuff . . . And, um, they actually have a class, for, like, you can learn Vietnamese . . . I used to take classes . . . 'cause my parents didn't want me to forget the language. (Asian American Diffused ERI 17-year-old female student)

Our family had, uh . . . like my grandfather had been very involved in the, what's called, "The Dutch Union" . . . It's not very, like, local or anything . . . but we went out there, and it was a huge thing of just learning, uh, a lot about other people and . . . what kind of groups would relate to who I am. (White Achieved ERI 17-year-old male student)

These family-community connections in our data were consistent with a transactional perspective on socialization and identity development (Hughes et al., 2016) and extant research on family ethnic-racial socialization (Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020; Yoon et al., 2017). Adolescents' examples specifically pointed to how their families engage in ethnic-racial socialization by searching for and participating in opportunities that are available in the community, a process that may be unique from ethnic-racial socialization in the home and is uninterpretable without considering the intersecting influences of both family and community contexts. The ways in which family-community intersections inform adolescent ERI development may vary by the history of ethnic-racial group representation in particular geographic regions (Umaña-Taylor & Bámaca, 2004) and by neighborhoods within the same region (White et al., 2018). This variability in the extent to which families can access community resources to support youth ERI development has implications for study sampling decisions and measurement in family ethnic-racial socialization research. For example, the extent to which community-based settings are involved in families' socialization practices, and therefore serve consequential roles in promoting adolescents' exploration process, may differ by place-specific legacies formed by local/state policies, residential segregation, and immigration. Despite the

context-specific nature of family-community socialization intersections, it is notable that youth with Achieved and Diffused ERI from all ethnic-racial backgrounds in our study discussed this influence on their ERI development (Table 3), suggesting that ties between families and community settings (be they local or otherwise) may be a universal context of adolescents' ethnic-racial socialization.

Participants also explained learning about their ERI by engaging in cultural activities with family and with their peers, which often occurred in community-based settings:

Um, well when I was, like, 14, my parents made me join like this dance group with them. And it was like, more about, it was like dancing but kind of like a play in a way. And it was, like, depicting the events of La Virgen de Guadalupe . . . And, yeah, like, a whole bunch of friends went, and, they pretty much just dragged me along too. (Latino Achieved ERI 16-year-old male student)

When brainstorming ways that youth can be supported in this regard, youth in Diffused ERI groups also mentioned bringing family and peers together:

We said that, like, we could go do, try new things . . . try new opportunities to, like, the people that know, like, to go with their friends and families . . . Um, we'd go to like a restaurant that has, like, heritage type of food, or play, like, a sport or a game, that, um, has to do with heritage. (White Diffused ERI 18-year-old male student)

Family-peer intersections in our data were consistent with notions from the triadic model of adolescent, parent, and peer relationships (Bornstein et al., 2013), emphasizing the dynamic ways in which transactions between parents and peers shape adolescent development. Our participants spoke to family-peer intersections over and above learning from family or peers in isolation, which may reflect peer influence reinforcing the choices parents make and/or parents selecting into peer and community networks that share mutual goals for ethnic-racial socialization. Prior research has shown the additive and interactive effects of family and peer socialization on ERI development in quantitative studies (Wang et al., 2015; Wang & Benner, 2016). Our qualitative findings indicate that adolescents learn about their ERI through opportunities that connect their family and peers and support adolescents' learning about and celebrating cultural heritage traditions. Given the relatively limited empirical work that has examined these intersections, future research is warranted, especially because this work could inform ERI-based intervention programs to promote family-peer connections. Unanswered

questions that remain include the extent to which the benefits of these connections may vary by the ethnic-racial match between adolescents' family and peer settings, or the ethnic-racial diversity of peer groups.

Participants of all ethnic-racial and ERI developmental status groups in our study also described learning from their family through the process of watching movies or TV and reading books, magazines, or newspapers related to their ethnic-racial background. For example:

Um, like, it could be something small, like, um, my mom purchased this DVD . . . called um, "The History of Melanin," and um, it tells all about the origins of Black people, and like, whatnot. And now we were thinking about holding, like, bringing some of our family members over to my grandmother's house to watch it, and to gain more experience of our culture. (Black Diffused ERI 15-year-old male student)

As another example, when explaining how he has learned about his ERI, an Asian American Achieved ERI 18-year-old male student started to explain, "Well, my parents bought like a lot of Korean books," to which an Asian American Achieved ERI 16-year-old female student agreed, "Oh my god, I was gonna say the same thing!" The pervasiveness with which youth of ethno-racially diverse backgrounds talked about their family sharing in this process together through culturally-related media may signal the significance of these opportunities.

For Latino and Asian American adolescents in Achieved ERI groups in our study, specifically, examples of family cultural socialization also included interacting and communicating on social media:

I have tías that are always on, like, Facebook. And like, every time I'm in class or something I get tagged in a picture, or something. And then, like, the whole picture will be, like, this whole thing of, like, La Virgen, or like, Jesús, you know, anything. And . . . like, my tías are always tagging me in it, or like, they'll comment on my pictures. (Latina Achieved ERI 15-year-old female student)

Yeah, like, I know my cousin, um, in Cambodia, like, she did not know any English at all, and now she does, through like Internet and Facebook . . . We use Skype so, like, she can speak English, and then she can write in, in English . . . And my mom uses Skype all the time. It's, it's so annoying because, like, three o'clock in the morning she'll be, like, on Skype . . . 'cause it's different, like, time zones. (Asian American Achieved ERI 17-year-old female student)

These examples point to ways adolescents engage in and benefit from cross-cultural exchange to learn about their ERI by communicating online with family members living in other regions or countries when there are more limited opportunities for in-person interaction.

These family-media intersections in our data demonstrate how representation in traditional media forms (e.g., movies, TV, books) and technological advances in online communication can provide a setting for conversations and interactions between adolescents and their extended family members, thus promoting adolescents' ERI exploration opportunities. Although the risks of ethnic-racial discrimination in online settings have been well documented, especially social media (Bravo et al., 2019; Tynes et al., 2020), ever-advancing online applications also serve as critical social contexts of youth identity exploration (Davis et al., 2020). Though not yet robustly considered with respect to ERI development, specifically, prior studies have shown the importance of parents' media-related attitudes and practices for supporting youth digital media consumption (Coyne et al., 2017). The current findings suggest that, in addition to the threats posed by media, there may be advantages for youth ERI development through opportunities for family ethnic-racial socialization to reach youth using media platforms that are entertaining and interesting to them (e.g., movies, social media).

Participants also spoke about how family members have helped them learn about their culture and gain an understanding of their ERI in the context of school assignments:

Um, and I think it was last year we did a project in [*teacher's name*] class, um, but we did a project on, um, ancestry and, like, we had to research our family tree and made me talk about like, uh, where my family's from. And I asked my grandparents about it, and just made a family tree about how that happened. (White Achieved ERI 17-year-old male student)

Other youth shared a desire for cultural socialization opportunities that might become available with more integrated communication between their family and school. For example, when discussing what schools can do to better support youth ERI development, a participant explained:

Like, if, you know how . . . parents teach you about who you are, like, as in Blacks or Mexicans. Like, if the school teaches about us . . . as in our heritage, like, who we are, then we can go back and tell our family who, who they are . . . Then your family's gonna think, "Oh, maybe you guys do need to learn that." And then it can be a home thing and a school thing. (Black Diffused ERI 16-year-old female student)

Family-School intersections in our data illustrated how adolescents' active engagement in exploration of their ERI is motivated by efforts from both family and their school that can provide mutually reinforcing opportunities for youth to gain a personal connection to their cultural history and background. These findings help to contextualize prior experimental research demonstrating that spending school time to support youth ERI exploration has greater impacts for ethno-racially diverse youth who have also been socialized about their cultural heritage from family (Sladek et al., 2021). Based on the ways youth in our study discussed these opportunities, and consistent with culturally sustaining pedagogy (Paris, 2012), spending structured time in school through family history assignments in the curriculum may elevate the significance of ERI exploration with family as a learning goal for adolescents.

Notably, White and Black youth in both Achieved and Diffused ERI status groups shared examples of learning about their ERI through a combination of both family and school assignments but Asian American and Latino youth did not discuss these same assignments (Table 3). Comparisons of ethnic-racial socialization contexts across ethnic-racial groups was beyond the scope of the current study; thus, the reason for this absence is unclear. It is possible that Asian American and Latino adolescents did not mention these family history assignments because this was a less salient or memorable way they learned about their ERI, and they chose to discuss other forms of socialization that were more meaningful to them (e.g., across the many codes included in Table 2 and Table 3). Given the significant barriers that exist for many students, particularly students of color and students from immigrant families, to integrate their family cultural backgrounds and ERI with school in the U.S. education system that privileges Euro-centric monoculturalism (Tyler et al., 2008), more research is needed that examines how family and school cultural socialization practices operate together to inform ERI development for all adolescents.

Ethnic-Racial Socialization Intersections Between Peer, School, Community-Based, and Media Contexts

Considering social contexts outside the family setting, participants described multiple ways in which learning about their ERI occurred through a constellation of intersecting influences, including from their peers, in school, in community-based settings, and from media. For example, participants explained the process of sharing and learning about cultural differences from peers in the school setting:

Um, two years ago, I went to like, a really Christian school, and they like, like, mixing kids together, so that way, you can learn about different cultures, and, I got picked to, um, help . . . be the president of the festival for Black History Month . . . Some of the kids learned, like, how, um, the other kids dress in Africa, and, we had a bunch of food and stuff, and it was pretty fun. (Black Achieved ERI 14-year-old female student)

Um, well at our school every two years we have this assembly about ethnicity . . . and like, every ethnicity from the school, like, represents in that assembly. . . . Like, they say, I think it's the "I Have a Dream" speech? . . . And they take turns saying, like, every two lines in a different language, and it . . . sounds really cool. And like, there are like different dances and performances from different cultures . . . And, that made it really interesting. (Asian American Diffused ERI 17-year-old female student)

It is notable that most examples of these peer-school intersections were specific to memorable school-sponsored occasions or special events outside the standard curriculum. This trend has been supported by prior research, which has shown that school ethnic-racial socialization efforts generally remain limited to commemorating key figures and events of historical significance in racial justice movements (Byrd & Hope, 2020). Though relatively infrequent, participants explained that these cultural-related school events were memorable because they provided fun and interesting opportunities to learn about themselves and their peers with respect to ERI. In our sample, only youth of color in Achieved and Diffused ERI status groups (Table 3) gave examples of this intersecting context. Future research is needed to explore whether and how these types of school events present peer-based ERI learning opportunities for White youth, while also examining the ways in which White youth are socialized regarding race and learn about their ERI through content in standard school curricula that privileges the histories of the majority culture group.

Participants of all ethnic-racial and ERI developmental status groups reported learning with peers outside of school by engaging in cultural activities in community-based settings. For example, considering religious affiliation as part of his ERI, a White Achieved ERI 16-year-old male student described, "Uh, I go to a Catholic youth group . . . So we'll talk about different things in our religion and then we'll talk about how we feel about it . . . sort of bond." As another example:

Every year here, they have, like, a Puerto Rican festival . . . I always go to it . . . just to, like, see all the different people from my culture . . . It's, like, downtown . . . like, a big parade, and they have, like, a party after, which is more for like, older people, like our age and older . . . So, it's pretty cool. (Latina Diffused ERI 16-year-old female student)

Participants' many examples of how their peers are involved in ethnic-racial socialization, for youth of diverse ethnic-racial groups and at different cross-sections of ERI development, suggest the importance of considering opportunities within both school and community-based settings for youth to share and learn from same and different ethnic-racial peers. Prior quantitative research has identified variability in peer influence on adolescents' ERI as a function of school and/or geographical region differences in ethnic-racial diversity (Santos et al., 2017). Taken together with our current findings, this suggests that future research is needed to develop additional measures and use multiple methods to unpack how opportunities for ethnic-racial socialization intersect within the multiple nested contexts of adolescents' communities, schools, and peer groups to shape ERI development.

As an intersection between media and school, participants of all ethnic-racial backgrounds also reported using the Internet when completing school assignments to conduct research and learn more about their ERI, which also involved sharing the results of this process with classmates and teachers:

I was doing a project on India, so obviously I was, like, "okay, I'm gonna put some of the stuff that I know," but then I used the Internet to find out, like, different stuff that, you know, I would have never known of . . . I used it to my advantage to do research on, like, what obviously I didn't know, and then I presented that to, like, the class . . . And then I got to, like, share that [with] everybody else, and so it . . . it was there as, like, my research tool so to say. (Asian American Achieved ERI 18-year-old female student)

Another student shared how he used the Internet for a school assignment to research SB 1070, a state policy that allowed police to detain individuals who were not able to prove their citizenship on request, which sanctioned racial profiling of the Latino community:

I did a report, for uh, for class, it was about, SB 1070 . . . And like . . . I was saying why it shouldn't be implemented, because we've done a lot of great things for this country, we've had a lot of good ideas, like, America would basically be nothing without us. [I

searched] the Internet, and then in the news. (Latino Achieved ERI 15-year-old male student)

As technology rapidly advances and adolescents increasingly navigate online learning environments, it is important for ERI research to examine how educators incorporate Internet use in their classrooms and scaffold youth's active efforts to engage in exploring their cultural heritage. Keeping in mind the potential for ethnic-racial-related online interactions to be detrimental for adolescent development (Tynes et al., 2020), the pace with which technological innovation continues in schools may also bring about transformative positive opportunities for adolescents' ERI exploration. In line with culturally sustaining pedagogy (Paris, 2012), educators' critically conscious use of online tools may provide one avenue to infuse curriculum with opportunities for promoting adolescent ERI development in ways that align with youth interest and facility with technology. Bravo and colleagues (2019) offer several useful recommendations in this regard.

As an intersection between media and community-based settings, participants' descriptions of attending and participating in community cultural events were often indistinguishable from the salient influence of culturally relevant media forms, such as music and art. For example, when participants were asked about events they have attended that have helped them learn more about their ethnicity and cultural heritage, a Latina Achieved ERI 15-year-old female student shared, "Like, I've been to concerts at, like, [local entertainment venue]. They've had, like, all these famous, like [Hispanic/Latino] singers, like, from Bandas and all that. I've gone to those." Other examples included attending plays and other live performances that provided opportunities for youth to learn about their cultural heritage in community settings. This intersection was only discussed among youth of color in our study (Table 3). To our knowledge, less research has considered intersections between media (e.g., music, theatre, art) and community-based contexts as settings for ethnic-racial socialization, highlighting a cultural ecology for ERI development warranting further study. Promoting communal opportunities to see, hear, and experience one's cultural traditions at community events outside the home through memorable music, theatre, and other forms of art and entertainment may play a uniquely promotive role in fostering adolescents' ERI development. As significant variability exists in youth's access to these opportunities in their communities, this context-specific influence may

require innovation in study sampling, measures, and methods to consider this intersection amidst the constellation of other contextual factors that shape ERI.

Everyday Settings of Ethnic-Racial Socialization Within Systems of Racial Oppression

Participants described multiple ways in which the process of learning about their ERI in everyday social settings takes place within systems of racial oppression. In other words, examining the influence of social context on adolescents' ERI development was incomplete without attention to the broader macro-level societal and historical context of race and ethnicity in which all proximal settings of adolescents' lives are embedded. This theme emerged through our analysis of intersections between sociohistorical context influences and ethnic-racial socialization that occurs in school, community-based settings, peers, and the media, respectively (Table 3). Specifically, youth of color described how learning about their ERI included an adaptive need to react to, make sense of, and overcome messages from teachers in school, other adults, peers, and the media that marginalize their identities.

For example, when participants were asked to share specific experiences that have helped them learn about their ERI from reading books, some youth of color described receiving disheartening and invalidating messages from teachers and the school curriculum:

I have an English research paper and then my teacher told us to look for someone revolutionary, and I chose Emiliano Zapata. He's like, um, kind of like a Mexican Robin Hood, I guess . . . And then, like, I asked my teacher about that . . . and she said if we could give her three reasons that she let us do the person . . . And I gave her my three reasons, and then she said I couldn't do him. Because he wasn't American, and I was kind of bummed out because I was like excited about learning about him . . . Because he was part of my, my heritage and all that stuff. (Latino Achieved ERI 16-year-old male student)

We're doing, like, a junior research paper . . . I told my teacher that, um, I wanted to do Thurgood Marshall. She was like, "Who is that?" I was like, "Okay." I told her that I wanted to do W. E. B. Du Bois. She's like, "Who is that?" I was like, "Okay." And I was like, Bessie Smith. She was like, "Who is that?" I was like, "Okay." . . . Like, it's a lot of teachers that really don't know about, that don't know about history at all . . . but like, I'm done with the basics." (Black Diffused ERI 17-year-old male student)

Teachers lacking the knowledge and critical awareness to support students in accessing and exploring their cultural histories for school assignments, thereby marginalizing youth of color through unfair treatment in school, may serve as a unique instigator of ERI exploration through motivation to push back against and resist these norms. Our data support growing theory and research investigating how youth of color must learn to critically analyze and respond to multiple levels of inequity in their educational settings (Aldana & Byrd, 2015). This exploration process unfolds within the sociohistorical context of the U.S. education system, in which there is a significant ethnic-racial mismatch between public school teachers (79% White) and their students (48% White; Hussar et al., 2020), as well as widespread calls for teachers to improve their competencies for addressing ethnic-racial-related issues in the classroom (Quintana & Mahgoub, 2016). Prior research has pointed to the promise that emerges for adolescent ERI development when educators become positive changemakers, including the adoption of culturally sustaining pedagogy and other promotive school cultural socialization practices that allow students to bring their identities into the classroom (Del Toro & Wang, 2021; Paris, 2012; Umaña-Taylor et al., 2018). In line with this prior research, our findings suggest that intervention is essential to build supportive contexts in which teachers and other adult school leaders build equity by affording positive opportunities for all students to learn about their ERI in school.

In describing how they have learned about and come to understand their ERI, youth of color also discussed experiencing discrimination from adults outside of school in everyday neighborhood settings. For example, when asked to share their experiences of what can make it harder to figure out what their ERI means to them, a Black Diffused ERI 14-year-old female student explained, “Because sometimes when we like go to the mall, maybe, like the store, or sometimes, the people that work there they, like, follow you around and make sure you’re not stealing anything, and that really you’re not trying to do anything,” to which a Black Diffused ERI 14-year-old male student added, “Well, no that happened to me one time at Walmart, well, uh . . . I’d seen this dude, he was spying on me from the other side. And when I was walking by the store, like, he kinda, followed me halfway, and he went back in. Yeah.” As another example:

Um, yesterday we went to [nearby town], to go see a car my dad wanted. And, like, we were walking in the city. And, like, we noticed that there was just White people all around us and we were the only ones . . . like Mexicans or ANY color at all, and, like, as we were walking down . . . the sidewalks, everybody just turned their heads and looked at

us like we were just, I don't know, we were, like we weren't supposed to be there kind of.
(Latino Achieved ERI 16-year-old male student)

These examples of the pervasive nature of ethnic-racial discrimination confronting youth of color as they move through their community settings outside the home and school are consistent with a transactional view of ethnic-racial socialization, discrimination, and identity development (Hughes et al., 2016) and with prior research documenting ways in which the realities of racism in adolescents' everyday lives inform how they learn about and understand their identity (Spencer et al., 1997; Yoon et al., 2017). The salience of discrimination, prejudice, and racism in adolescents' everyday experiences likely vary as a function of differences in ethnic-racial diversity across geographic regions and across neighborhood contexts in the same region (Pasco & White, 2020), suggesting the need for further research to continue investigating contextual variability in how racism in everyday community-based settings shapes adolescents' ERI.

Participants also explained how they have learned about and become aware of societal ethnic-racial stereotypes and experienced discrimination through interactions with peers:

Yeah, it makes me really mad when people stereotype, 'cause like, well I have one of my friends and she's like really close to me but she, she calls every single Asian [person] Chinese . . . And I'm not Chinese . . . And she always says, "Oh I love Chinese food." I'm like, "That's not Chinese, sushi is not Chinese, it's not." And I keep telling her that, but she continues to call everyone Chinese. I'm like, "Stop, it's rude." (Asian American Achieved ERI 16-year-old female student)

When asked to share experiences that can make it difficult to figure out what their ERI means to them, a Black Diffused ERI 15-year-old female student also described being stereotyped by peers: "I think that school could make it harder [to figure out what your ERI means to you], because your peers automatically, like, if you're . . . if the color of your skin is, like, Black, they automatically think that, like, you're gonna act Black or, whatever." When describing barriers to learning about and understanding their ERI, participants also shared frustration that comes with repeated exposure to stereotypes and discrimination in the media:

I don't know, but I kind of notice here if you watch the news, you don't, you always hear something bad about México. You never hear, like, the good things . . . And it's like, there is good things, but all you mention are the bad. (Latina Achieved ERI 16-year-old female student)

Um, and I think the biggest [barrier to understanding ERI], for me that I think is definitely media . . . including television, movies, social networking, all that stuff. Um, makes it hard for you because you have a bunch of different opinions being thrown at you from all different angles, you know, and it's not just coming from, you know, like White people or Mexicans, like it's coming from your race as well, and it's just . . . from everywhere and it's hard to find yourself in all of that. (Black Diffused ERI 16-year-old female student)

These intersections we found between peers, media, and the broader sociohistorical context were consistent with notions from PVEST (Spencer et al., 1997), which extends Bronfenbrenner's model to consider how identity development may be a response to contextual stressors that are generated by stereotypes in society and other forms of marginalization. Evidence for this pathway has been supported by quantitative studies finding that peer-based discrimination predicted adolescents' proactive efforts to cope with discrimination (Montoro et al., 2020) and ERI exploration (Del Toro et al., 2021). Adolescents' ERI may be informed by a process of resistance and accommodation to negative stereotypes that are projected on them by their peers (Way et al., 2008). Indeed, research has found that ethnic-racial harassment, teasing, and microaggressions from peers are relatively common, even in discussions among friends (Douglass et al., 2016; Moffitt & Syed, 2020). The frequency with which youth are exposed to and must make sense of negative stereotypes in the media, coupled with the heightened salience of peer discussions about these stereotypes during adolescence, though challenging and unfair for youth of color, may encourage a process of self-discovery, by which adolescents explore their ERI to actively avoid or resist becoming an example of the ethnic-racial stereotypes they learn about (Spencer et al., 1997; Way et al., 2013). Our findings illustrate ways in which ethnic-racial socialization in peer- and media-based contexts must be understood within the broader sociohistorical context of racism, which positions stereotypes, discrimination, and other forms of racial oppression as key influences on ERI development.

Analyzing these intersections between macro-level systems of racial oppression and more proximal settings of ethnic-racial socialization revealed more limited discussion among White adolescents, though there were some examples regarding peer and media contexts (Table 3). For instance, a White Diffused ERI 16-year-old female student acknowledged the pervasiveness of ethnic-racial-related jokes among peers in school, though was hesitant to share many details:

“There is not a day that doesn’t go by without different ethnicity jokes. I don’t wanna repeat it . . . I’ll write it down for you but I’m not gonna say it.” When asked about ways they have learned about their ERI through the Internet, participants shared examples of ethnic-racial stereotypes about White people they see on social media:

Where all the stereotypes come from is, like, you know, you see pictures of, like, girls wearing UGG boots and leggings and holding Starbucks, and it’s, like, “White girl selfie!” or something like that. And it’s just, like . . . I think that the Internet has everything to do with . . . like, the stereotypes . . . Yeah, but like, if you’re on, like, Twitter or something you see that kind of stuff all the time. (White Diffused ERI 15-year-old female student)

I just see things [online], like, that are kind of racist . . . towards some ethnicities, in a way, but they’re kinda joking . . . and it’s like, “Things White people like” . . . Like, people being racist, but it’s, like, kinda been, I don’t know, like, toned down. (White Achieved ERI 17-year-old male student)

Prior ethnographic and qualitative work have shown distinct socialization patterns regarding the ways in which White youth learn about race, which can lead to a tendency to avoid recognition of racial privilege and characterize race-related discussions as uncomfortable or concerning (Hagerman, 2018). Thus, we expect that the limited conversations among White youth in our study related to this theme may signal an important absence or hesitancy to engage in discussions about race and racism that requires further investigation. Future qualitative research will prove useful to follow up more directly about how White adolescents perceive and understand the roles of systemic racism and racial privilege in the process of learning about their ERI.

Conclusions, Limitations, and Future Directions

Through the strengths of consensual qualitative research, this study revealed the complex ways in which ethno-racially diverse adolescents learn about their ERI through the influences of multiple intersecting social contexts. The results of our analysis of adolescent focus group interviews provide important avenues for expanding extant cultural-ecological theories of development as they pertain to ethnic-racial socialization and the developmental processes of exploring and coming to understand what it means to be a member of one’s ethnic-racial group. Though often cited in the developmental science of ERI research, the theoretical assumptions of the bioecological model (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2006) and extensions thereof (García Coll et

al., 1996; Spencer et al., 1997), which emphasize dynamic cross-context transactions as drivers of development, have been rendered difficult to test empirically in the prevailing positivist research paradigms of developmental and education research that advantage experimental and quantitative longitudinal methods. In line with calls in the literature to consider social contexts of ERI development (Hughes et al., 2016; Rogers et al., 2020; Seaton et al., 2017; Umaña-Taylor, 2016), our analysis demonstrated multiple ways in which ethnic-racial socialization processes span social context intersections (a) between family and community-based contexts, peers, media, and school; (b) between peers, school, community-based, and media settings; and (c) between the broader sociohistorical context of race and racism and these proximal microsystems. The social context intersections found in this study illustrate relations between microsystems that form the mesosystem in the bioecological model (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2006) as a unique layer of influence in adolescent ERI development, as well as notions from ecological/transactional theories that emphasize interconnections between adolescent ethnic-racialization socialization, discrimination, and identity (Hughes et al., 2016). These results add to a growing empirical base, encouraging researchers to further examine family ethnic-racial socialization in concert with other social contexts of development. Our work also demonstrates the ubiquity of ethnic-racial socialization outside the family setting and highlights the ways in which adolescent ERI development unfolds within a broader sociohistorical context of race and racism that requires youth to respond to learning about societal ethnic-racial stereotypes and experiencing ethnic-racial-based discrimination (Figure 1 in Supplementary Materials).

Our study design and the ethnic-racial diversity of the school context in which the study took place afforded the opportunity to hear the perspectives of adolescents from diverse ethnic-racial backgrounds at different phases in the ERI development process. Discussions with adolescents from these different groups revealed a high level of consistency across ethnic-racial groups (e.g., Black, Latino, White, Asian American) and ERI developmental status (e.g., Achieved, Diffused) for ways in which family ethnic-racial socialization intersects with other social context influences, such as learning about one's cultural background through attending community-based cultural events with family, family connections with community-based organizations, exposure to cultural-related media (e.g., books, movies) in the family setting, as well as for ways in which ethnic-racial socialization also occurs through engaging in cultural activities with peers in community-based settings. Given that these examples emerged from both

Achieved and Diffused ERI status groups across all ethnic-racial groups in our study, future research should aim to capture the unique integration of family, community, and peer contexts in assessing how adolescents learn about their ERI. Furthermore, efforts to support ERI development with ethno-racially diverse adolescents should focus on promoting synergy between family, community, and peer contexts, as these intersections were salient for all youth in our study.

Other examples in our data revealed a higher level of differentiation across groups, such as how adolescents learned about their ERI from media influences in multiple social settings. For instance, communicating about one's cultural background with family through social media and learning through exposure to cultural media in community-based settings (e.g., concerts, plays) emerged more consistently from adolescents in Achieved ERI groups and for adolescents of color. As theory suggests a developmental progression and context-dependent process of ERI formation across adolescence (Umaña-Taylor et al., 2014; Williams et al., 2020), it is not surprising that youth with Achieved ERI provided more examples of how the process of exploration occurs in multiple settings. Perhaps youth with Achieved ERI expressed more integration of these learning opportunities across multiple contexts because they have internalized and made meaning out of these experiences to a greater extent at this point in their identity formation, allowing them to reflect and draw on connections across different experiences and voice this in a group discussion. It is also possible that Achieved youth have shown greater agency in seeking out these opportunities, thus resulting in a bidirectional effect between individual identity development and socialization that strengthens ERI over time, as has been shown in longitudinal research (e.g., Umaña-Taylor et al., 2013). Future research should consider whether incorporating media-based opportunities to learn about ERI may provide interesting and meaningful ways to engage with ethno-racially diverse youth with Diffused ERI and with White youth.

Another prominent source of differentiation across groups emerged in our data from analyzing intersections between the macro-level sociohistorical context (e.g., systemic racism, societal ethnic-racial stereotypes) and everyday settings of school, community-based contexts, peers, and media. Only adolescents of color shared examples of experiencing ethnic-racial discrimination from teachers in school and in everyday neighborhood settings, consistent with systemic racism in the U.S. that perpetuates the prevalence of unfair treatment of youth of color,

while conferring power and privilege to White youth who benefit from this system, oftentimes unknowingly. Though White youth did voice an awareness of stereotypes, such as ethnic-racial-related jokes made among peers and ethnic-racial stereotypes they see on social media, they offered relatively few examples within this theme. As called for by other researchers (e.g., Hagerman, 2018; Seaton et al., 2017), more studies on ethnic-racial socialization among White youth are needed to answer critical questions: How do messages that youth from the dominant majority culture receive across multiple social contexts (e.g., family, school, peers) coalesce to inform ERI development? What are the implications of ERI developmental processes for supporting critical consciousness and anti-racist beliefs and actions for White youth?

Despite its many contributions, there are limitations to acknowledge. First, our study consisted of focus group discussions with adolescents in one high school setting in the southwestern U.S. Further work is needed to understand the extent to which processes identified in the current study generalize to the broader population of youth. Second, although we intentionally recruited a sample that was diverse with respect to ethnic-racial group, age, and ERI development, the demographics of our study site limited our ability to explore these questions with youth from all ethnic-racial backgrounds and thus the experiences of Native American and multiracial youth are not uniquely reflected in our study. Third, due to practical constraints of data collection, the focus group facilitators' ethnic-racial background mirrored the ethnic-racial background of Latino or White participants, but not of the Black or Asian American participants. As a result, it is possible that researchers were not able to gain deeper insights into culture-specific features of ethnic-racial socialization for Black and Asian American adolescents based on their own ethnic-racial backgrounds. For example, though many participants were eager to share their experiences in all of the focus groups, some youth may have felt less comfortable talking about ethnicity and race with an adult who did not share their background. We are not able to know how this feature of the study impacted our findings and conclusions. Conducting focus groups with more homogenous groups and with same-group facilitators may provide opportunities for different discussions that reveal additional insights about adolescents' ERI. As prior scholarship has suggested (Ponterotto, 2010), we encourage future research to consider the diversity of research teams and strive towards greater diversity in research with ethno-racially diverse youth for the benefit of better science. Finally, the conceptual framing of this study focused on ways in which social contexts shape adolescents' ERI development, and thus our

analysis cannot speak to how adolescents and their ERI development also shape social contexts, an exciting avenue for future research considering bidirectional person-context influences (e.g., Umaña-Taylor et al., 2013).

Looking forward, our study points to important avenues for future research. First, this study highlights the value of qualitative inquiry for centering youth perspectives regarding their socialization experiences and identity development, as well as the utility of consensual qualitative research approaches to infuse the data analysis process with the perspectives of a diverse team. Future studies, both qualitative and quantitative, will benefit from rigorous consideration of reflexivity and representation using a team-based approach to developmental science, particularly when examining the complex roles of ethnicity and race (and thus, power and privilege) in human development. Second, examining social context intersections of ethnic-racial socialization will require methodological innovation for future research to adequately capture intricacies in adolescents' ERI development across social context domains. Although some existing quantitative survey measures assess, for example, ethnic-racial socialization based in both family and community (Umaña-Taylor et al., 2004) or family and peer (Wang et al., 2015) settings, research paradigms outside large-scale quantitative survey approaches may also prove useful for examining ERI development at the intersections of multiple social contexts. Experience sampling (i.e., daily diary) methods may be particularly useful for qualitative, quantitative, and mixed-methods analysis of dynamic social influences on adolescents' ethnic-racial-related experiences and identity exploration as they unfold in real time in daily life.

As our study revealed multiple intersections when examining two contexts of ethnic-racial socialization together, future research should aim to use these intersecting contexts as a starting point for asking adolescents questions about their ERI development in ways that account for a higher degree of interplay across multiple socialization settings. For example, given that adolescents discussed ethnic-racial stereotypes and awareness of racism they see online as ways they receive ERI-related messages, how do adolescents process these experiences by talking with family, peers, or teachers? How do these conversations promote or hinder positive ERI exploration? The results of this study provide important contextual information for ERI-based intervention programs designed for families, community organizations, schools, and peer groups. Future research should develop and examine the efficacy of training models for practitioners working with youth in these settings. In line with our adolescent participants' perspectives, it is

critical to identify variability in the barriers and opportunities that exist to support evidence-based efforts that promote the normative developmental process of youth exploring their ERI.

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Table 1

Summary of Adolescent Participants by Focus Group (N = 98)

ERI developmental status	Ethnic-Racial self-identification	School grade	n of focus group	ERI Exploration M	ERI Resolution M
Achieved ERI: High exploration and resolution	Black	9 th -10 th	7	3.21	3.70
		11 th -12 th	5	3.14	3.65
	Latino	9 th -10 th	8	3.02	3.64
		11 th -12 th	8	2.98	3.80
	White	9 th -10 th	7	2.54	3.58
		11 th -12 th	7	2.58	3.68
	Asian American	11 th -12 th	7	3.18	3.56
Diffused ERI: Low exploration	Black	9 th -10 th	8	2.15	2.55
		11 th -12 th	7	2.11	2.29

and resolution	Latino	9 th -10 th	6	1.99	2.69
		11 th -12 th	5	2.26	2.65
	White	9 th -10 th	10	1.70	2.23
		11 th -12 th	10	1.79	2.33
	Asian American	9 th -10 th	3	2.04	2.48
		11 th -12 th	3	2.04	2.48

Note. ERI = ethnic-racial identity. The sample size of Asian American 9th-10th grade students was inadequate for cluster analysis to classify by ERI developmental status, and thus, focus groups were not formed for these students. Means for ERI Exploration and Resolution from confirmatory k-means cluster analysis solutions from full quantitative survey sample.

Table 2

Summary of Codes for Ways in Which Adolescents Learn About Their Ethnic-Racial Identity Via Social Context Influences

<u>Family</u>		<u>Peers</u>	<u>School</u>
• Connections to family ancestry • Family moving to new neighborhood/region/country • Cultural artifacts (e.g., family photos, artwork, journals) • Awareness of place/location of family origin • Traveling to or living in family place of origin • Watching, reading, or listening to media with family (e.g., TV, news) • Sharing or preparing meals • Engaging in cultural traditions and rites of passage • Hearing stories from older family members • Enrolling youth in classes outside school	• Sharing cultural values • Role of parents • Role of grandparents, elders • Role of siblings • Role of extended family • Cultural activities outside the home • Family engagement in arts (e.g., dance, music, theatre) • Religious beliefs, customs, or traditions • Communicating with family across borders in other countries • Learning or using heritage language • Learning about cultural, ethnic, or racial differences within the family	• Diversity of peer group • Attitudes that peers have towards ethnic-racial identity • Discussions with peers • Sense of in-group affinity or belonging with same ethnic-racial group peers • Interactions on social media networks • Learning or using heritage language • Participating in cultural activities, traditions, and rites of passage • Engaging with peers' family members • Sharing or preparing meals • Experiencing ethnic-racial discrimination • Religious beliefs, customs, or traditions	• Class-specific influences, including school projects, assignments, and curriculum • Role of teachers • Student-led school club, including affinity groups • Going on school field trips • Sharing or learning about culture at school event • Learning about different cultures • Community member or organization coming into school or involvement in field trip • Learning through the arts (e.g., dance, music, theatre) • Learning or using heritage language in school
<u>Community-Based Contexts^a</u>		<u>Media</u>	<u>Sociohistorical Context</u>
• Attending community cultural events	• Learning or using heritage language	• Watching TV • Listening to music • Watching videos or movies	• Systems of racial oppression (e.g., racism) • Historical events

• Religious beliefs, customs, or traditions • Role of community member or neighbor • Colleges/universities in community • Attending cultural events of another ethnic-racial group • Participating in affinity group • Visiting museum or library • Participating in organized extracurricular activities	• Sense of togetherness, attachment, or belonging • Cultural norms or customs within and across communities • Neighborhood characteristics • Food • Hearing stories from community members • Learning about cultural differences within or between groups	• Seeing content on the Internet • Reading magazines or newspapers • Reading books • Seeing visual arts • Engaging on social media • Listening to, learning, or using heritage language • Learning about cultural differences • Playing video games	• Examples of historical progress or challenges to systemic inequities (e.g., activism) • Social class • Examples of historical figures, past and present • Group collective memory (what ethnic-racial group members have collectively experienced throughout history) • Reflecting on stereotypes • Examples of current events • Experiencing ethnic-racial discrimination • Awareness of language differences across contexts
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Note. Codes were applied to instances in the data when participants expressed how they have learned about their ethnic-racial identity via these social context domains. Thus, all codes are followed by the specifier, "...in reference to learning about ethnic-racial identity." ^aCommunity-based contexts included community organizations (e.g., places of worship, museums) and features of participants' own neighborhoods and other neighborhoods they move through, both locally and globally.

Table 3

Summary of Codes for Intersecting Contexts of Ethnic-Racial Socialization and Occurrence of Codes Across Adolescent Focus Groups

Social Context Domains		Code Occurrence in Adolescent Focus Group Discussions							
Intersecting Social Contexts of Family Ethnic-Racial Socialization		Asian American ^a		Black		Latino		White	
		Achieved	Diffused	Achieved	Diffused	Achieved	Diffused	Achieved	Diffused
		ERI	ERI	ERI	ERI	ERI	ERI	ERI	ERI
Family and Community-Based Settings	Attending cultural events in community-based settings with family	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Learning about cultural background through family connections with community-based organizations	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Family and Peers	Engaging in cultural activities with family and peers	X		X	X	X		X	X
Family and Media	Watching, reading, or listening to cultural-related media in the family setting	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	
	Communicating about cultural background with family through social media	X				X			
Family and School	Learning about cultural history through combination of family and school assignments			X	X			X	X
Ethnic-Racial Socialization Intersections of Peer, School, Community-Based, and Media Contexts		Asian American ^a		Black		Latino		White	
		Achieved	Diffused	Achieved	Diffused	Achieved	Diffused	Achieved	Diffused
		ERI	ERI	ERI	ERI	ERI	ERI	ERI	ERI
Peers and School	Sharing and learning about cultural differences from peers in school	X	X	X	X	X	X		

Peers and Community-Based Settings	Engaging in cultural activities with peers in community-based settings	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Media and School	Using the Internet to complete school assignments related to ethnic-racial background	X		X	X	X		X	
Media and Community-Based Settings	Watching or listening to cultural media in community-based settings	X		X	X	X			
Everyday Settings of Ethnic-Racial Socialization Within Systems of Racial Oppression		Asian American ^a		Black		Latino		White	
		Achieved ERI	Diffused ERI	Achieved ERI	Diffused ERI	Achieved ERI	Diffused ERI	Achieved ERI	Diffused ERI
Sociohistorical Context and School	Experiencing ethnic-racial discrimination from teachers in school				X	X			
Sociohistorical Context and Community-Based Settings	Experiencing ethnic-racial discrimination in everyday neighborhood settings		X		X	X			
Sociohistorical Context and Peers	Learning about societal ethnic-racial stereotypes and discrimination through peer interactions	X	X	X	X	X			X
Sociohistorical Context and Media	Learning about societal ethnic-racial stereotypes through the media			X	X	X		X	X

Note. X = code occurred in focus group discussion with adolescents of the ethnic-racial group designated in table columns. Other possible social context intersections in the data were reviewed and discussed, including Family and Sociohistorical Context, School and Community-Based Settings, and Peers and Media. Due to relatively less frequent recurrence in the data, final codes were not defined for these intersections.

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^a There were two focus groups with Asian American students in the 11th/12th grade, compared to four focus groups with students of other ethnic-racial backgrounds, due to inadequate sample size of 9th/10th grade students for cluster analysis to classify by ERI developmental status.

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